

The Pantheon

Built by the Emperor Hadrian c.128 CE, the Pantheon covered a temple erected by the Emperor Augustus's son-in-law, Marcus Agrippa, in 27 BCE. The exterior, fronted by a portico of granite Corinthian columns (eight wide, three deep), leads to a huge rotunda. The spectacular dome, a half-sphere of 44.3 metres (144 ft) in diameter, is exactly equal to its floor to summit height. The 8-metre (27-ft) oculus, or 'open eye', at its crown is the main source of light. In the dome, sunken panels, or coffers, create interest, but also serve to hollow out the concrete and reduce its load on the brick supporting wall. The use of low-density rock, such as pumice, in the upper parts of the dome also reduces weight. With a series of restraining arches, the wall features alternating, curved and squared recesses. Overall, it is an open, airy, unified space. Pantheon means 'all the gods', and in 609 it became the first temple to be consecrated as a Catholic church, renamed the Church of Santa Maria ad Martyres. The remains of many Christian martyrs were brought from the catacombs and buried beneath its floor.

